
Man City: Guardiola at his creepiest in (not) slamming 'Spanish referees'

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Man City: Guardiola at his creepiest in (not) slamming 'Spanish referees'

Erling Haaland scored two very Erling Haaland goals against Monaco, but Manchester City were denied three points by – of all things – an Eric Dier penalty, and while Pep Guardiola has “nothing to say to Spanish referees”, he also did have something to say, albeit indirectly, to Spanish referees.

There will have been a few of you (definitely not us) who were surprised to learn that Dier even played for Monaco, let alone that he is their designated penalty taker. And after he slammed the spot kick into the side-netting to earn the Ligue 1 side a last-gasp draw against City, Guardiola gave one of his most creepy, smiley interviews after the game in a tell-tale indicator of his frustration.

Having told a different reporter that he had “nothing to say to referees” when asked for his opinion on Monaco being awarded a penalty when Nico O'Reilly was adjudged to have used a high boot in the box on Dier, he then did have something to say on the incident.

“A really good game,” Guardiola said. “We made some decisions, we created a lot of chances. Unfortunately at the end we defended an unfair free-kick not perfectly, and we conceded a penalty that [Nico] touched the ball first, no intention. But it is what it is...”

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Having been asked to confirm whether he thought it was a penalty, Guardiola added: “I don't know. So, it's penalty. Given. That's all.”

Haaland's first goal saw him dart in behind the Monaco defence to get on the end of a beautifully weighted pass over the top by Josko Gvardiol, before he lifted the ball over Philipp Köhn. His second saw him flex his neck muscles to head Nico O'Reilly's cross into the far corner. As always, he didn't do much besides, but he's back to his very best this season in front of goal.

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“He played really good” was the revelation from Guardiola, who looked like a man who would rather grunt at the reporter's questions or use a facial expression to reveal his thoughts instead of providing those already scant responses, so clearly was he fuming after that late penalty denied his team victory.

But O'Reilly's boot was high, and while it's definitely the sort of foul for which the award of a penalty feels very unfair, the fact that he got a touch on the ball doesn't make the referee wrong in pointing to the spot.

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